The CareLeaders

Programme brochure · 2026 to 27

Mentors Who Care

Care experienced adults, trained, coached and supported to mentor children and young people in care.

For councils and virtual schools **Three training days** **Coaching throughout**

Contents

03 Why we created it

04 What it is

05 Who it is for

06 How it works

07 The mentor training

08 The mentor's journey

09 How mentors are supported

10 What changes, and what you keep

11 Case study: Norfolk

12 Your facilitator

13 Getting started

Mentors Who Care

Why we created it

Children in care meet a lot of adults who are paid to be there.

Social workers, carers, teachers, independent reviewing officers. Most of them are good at their jobs, and most of them change. Very few of them have been in care themselves.

A mentor who grew up in care, and has chosen to turn up, can reach a child in ways professionals often can't. Nothing needs explaining. That only works if the mentor is trained, safe and supported, and if the relationship lasts.



That's why we created Mentors Who Care.

The question we start from

Who cares?

People who have been in care.

Children in care asked for mentors who understand their journeys. Every mentor on the programme grew up in care. It is the whole point, so it comes first.

What it is

A peer mentoring scheme for your council or virtual school. Care experienced adults mentor children in care. We design it with them, train them, coach them as they start, and leave you with a scheme that keeps going.



A scheme built with mentors
Designed with the care experienced adults who will run it



Three training days
A month apart, face to face



Coaching throughout
Coaching and wellbeing groups, from day one



A readiness check
Before any mentor meets a child



Befriending, then goals
Trust first, then the GROW model



A scheme that lasts
Mentors who grow into trainers



Who this programme is for

For	Councils and virtual schools setting up or relaunching a mentoring scheme
Mentors	Care experienced adults aged 18 and over
Children	Children in care of school age and post-16, at school, college or in a children's home
Led by	A named lead in your virtual school or leaving care team

What it sets out to do

Someone who has been there.

Three objectives, for every scheme we build.

Relationships

Matches that last

One mentor, one child, starting with befriending.

Close and consistent, because that is what makes mentoring work.

Endings planned and talked about, never sudden.

Safety

Mentors who know the boundaries

Never promise secrecy.

Pass a worry on the same day, through your route.

Clear lines on messaging, gifts and meeting places.

Legacy

A scheme your service owns

Mentors who grow into trainers.

Roles, routines and an operating model you keep.

A readiness tracker for every new mentor.

What children and young people get



An adult alongside them who has been in care too



Someone there by choice, not because it is their job



Goals that are their own, and someone who notices



A mentor who knows what to do with a worry



An ending that is planned, not sudden

Five beads, five steps.

From the first design day to mentors meeting children, and beyond. Every scheme is shaped around your service, so dates and numbers are agreed with you at the start.

1	Design	Shape the scheme with the people who will mentor: why they want to, what they need, roles, referral, matching and recording. Your safeguarding route and payments agreed with you.
2	Recruit	A role description and a 4 to 6 week campaign to find care experienced adults who want to give something back. Your scheme runs the safer recruitment checks.
3	Train	Three one-day sessions, about a month apart: befriending and foundations, GROW and the dynamics of mentoring, then safeguarding, readiness and launch.
4	Ready and matched	A readiness check before any match. It is a conversation, not a test. Anyone not ready yet has another way to contribute while they build towards it.
5	Befriend, mentor, lead	One child per mentor. Befriending builds trust, GROW mentoring builds goals, and experienced mentors learn to train the next cohort.

Three days, a month apart.

Mentors try things between the days and bring their questions back. Every part opens with a story from a child's side, gives mentors the research that explains it and ends with something they practise in pairs.

Day 1
Befriending and foundations

Why mentor?
The adult who made a difference to you, your values, and what a mentor is and is not.

Befriending
The seven stages from referral to a first meeting with a trusted adult there, and a getting-to-know-you guide the child owns.

Sharing your story safely
What's mine, what I share with care and what I share freely, always asking whether it helps the child.

Day 2
GROW and the dynamics

GROW
Goal, Reality, Options, Way forward, practised in pairs.

The dynamics
The pull to rescue, a child testing you by going quiet, and noticing when the role stirs up your own memories.

Staying well
Psychological safety, compassion fatigue, and Spot, Soothe, Shift for the moments a meeting gets hard.

Day 3
Safeguarding, readiness and launch

Keeping children safe
Listening without promising secrecy, writing it down in the child's words and passing it on the same day.

Ready to start
Boundaries on messaging, gifts and meeting places, planning endings, and your readiness conversation.

Launch
Your first match, the coaching and wellbeing groups from here, and who to call.

The How to be a Mentor workbook maps every activity, so mentors can go back over it between the days. It also works on its own as a course.

Relationships first, then goals.

Mentors move at different speeds, and we say so from the start. Not ready yet is a direction, not a rejection: mentors can contribute as a **Speaker** or an **Advisor**, or through work with schools, while they build towards befriending.

1

Foundation training

Three days that give every mentor the same grounding

2

Coaching and readiness

Coaching and wellbeing groups, and a readiness check before any match

3

Befriending

One child per mentor, building trust before anything else

4

GROW mentoring

Structured goal-setting once the relationship is there

5

Train the trainer

Experienced mentors learn to train the next cohort



Seven stages of befriending

From the referral to a first activity the child chose, with a trusted adult there at the first meeting.

1. Referral
2. Read the referral
3. Call the young person
4. Meet with a trusted adult
5. Icebreakers
6. Getting-to-know-you guide
7. A first activity

Backed so they can stay.

Mentoring can bring a mentor's own time in care back to the surface. Support runs from the first training day to long after the first match.



Coaching, not supervision

Every mentor has a coach. What coaching covers, how often and how to reach them is agreed with each mentor at the start.



Wellbeing groups

Online groups between the training days and once mentoring starts, so mentors can talk through what the role stirs up with people who get it.



A readiness check

No one is matched until they are ready. The check is a conversation, not a test.



Another way to contribute

Mentors not ready to befriend a child can contribute as a Speaker or an Advisor, or through work with schools.



A clear route for a worry

Mentors never carry a worry alone. They know exactly who to pass it to, and they pass it on the same day.



Support as matches start

We stay alongside mentors through their first weeks of befriending, then hand the coaching and groups over to your team.

What changes

Children in care with someone who gets it.

01 **For children and young people.** An adult alongside them who has been in care too, is there by choice, and helps them set goals that are their own.

02 **For mentors.** Training, coaching and a community of mentors, so they can give something back safely and keep doing it.

03 **For your service.** A scheme built with the people who run it, and care experienced adults in roles that reach children in ways professionals often can't.

What you keep

Nothing we build stays ours.

With mentors who grow into trainers, your service can run the next cohort without us.

- **The How to be a Mentor workbook.** Every training activity mapped, for the sessions or on its own
- **Befriending and GROW guides.** With session templates and reflective tools
- **A readiness tracker.** A competency framework, so every mentor is ready before a match
- **Coaching and wellbeing routines.** Contracting, coaching prompts and a route for passing on a worry
- **A recruitment campaign.** A 4 to 6 week campaign and marketing toolkit
- **An operating model.** Roles, referral, matching, recording and outcomes

Case study

Norfolk Virtual School

Norfolk County Council · 2026 to 2027, in progress. Programme design, mentor training and coaching model.



Mentors who have been there.

The idea came from children in care.

Children in care told Norfolk Virtual School they wanted mentors who understood their journeys, so the virtual school set out to find care experienced adults to be those mentors. What it needed next was everything that turns a good idea into a safe scheme: training, a clear role, a way to match mentors with children, and support for mentors while they help someone else.

Design

Clear roles and a model for referral, matching and recording.

Recruit

A role description and a campaign to find mentors.

Train

Mentor training days, with coaching in between.

Launch

Readiness, first matches and handover to the virtual school.

Where it is now

The scheme is being built now. Mentors shape it as well as join it, and the support they get is coaching, agreed with them from the start. Mentors Who Care is built on what we are learning there.



Luke Rodgers BEM
Founder and CEO, The Care Leaders

Your facilitator

From care leaver to care leader.

Luke went into care at 10. At 15 he was living in a bed and breakfast, and at 18 in a caravan. He gave his first keynote at 19 and has spent his career since inside children's services, as a consultant, trainer, board member and national engagement lead.

He has spent his career building roles for care experienced people inside the services that shaped their lives: as a Young Person's Ambassador for the National Fostering Agency, on the programme board of the Mockingbird Family Model at The Fostering Network, and as the founder of the Care Leavers National Movement.

Mentors Who Care comes from the peer mentoring scheme he is building with Norfolk Virtual School, where care experienced adults have shaped the scheme with him from the first training day.

He founded The Care Leaders in 2017, and it has since worked with 36 local authorities and national bodies, including the Department for Education and the NHS.

- **Gold, Dual Perspective Leadership Award**
  iESE Public Sector Transformation Awards 2026
- **British Empire Medal**
  2018, for commitment to children and families
- **Knowledge Equity Fellow**
  Saïd Business School, University of Oxford, 2020 to 2021
- **Social Entrepreneur Fellow**
  School for Social Entrepreneurs, 2015 to 2017

Mentors Who Care

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Mentors Who Care

Getting started

Four steps to your first cohort.

1 **Get in touch**

Email us about your service, your children and young people, and the mentors you hope to find.

2 **Have an initial call**

We reply within 3 working days to book a call about your scheme and your dates.

3 **We provide a quote**

A clear price for your number of mentors and how much of the set-up you want us to do.

4 **We design it with your mentors**

Your prospective mentors are in the first design session within weeks.

What we need from you

- A named lead in your virtual school or leaving care team
- Your safeguarding route, agreed before training
- Safer recruitment checks, including an enhanced DBS
- A decision on payments, expenses and rewards for mentors
- Referrals of children who would like a mentor
- Staff who will take on coaching and wellbeing groups

Commissioned by your council or virtual school. Contact us for a price.

hello@thecareleaders.com

iese Awards GOLD Winner 2026 The Public Sector Transformation Awards

Children & Young People Now Awards 2023 Winner

Gold, Dual Perspective Leadership Award, iESE Public Sector Transformation Awards 2026.
Children & Young People Now Workforce Development Award 2023.

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